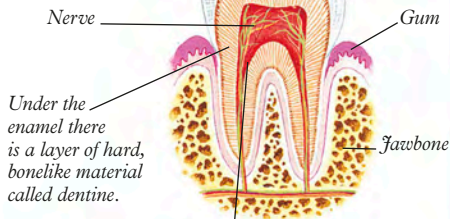


Inside story

Your teeth are alive. The part that sticks out from your gum is the crown. The part under the gum is the root.

Enamel is the hardest substance your body makes. A thin layer of it covers all your teeth.



The soft, middle part of the tooth is called the pulp. It contains nerves and blood vessels.

Your bumpy back teeth are called molars. They crush and grind food when you chew.

Sometimes people have extra teeth.

Canine teeth are sharp and pointed. They are used for tearing food.

There are molars on the bottom, too.



Brushing up

If you don't keep your teeth clean, bacteria build up to form a layer called plaque. If plaque builds up on your teeth, it can cause them to decay and even fall out. Brushing your teeth and gums after meals and before going to bed helps to remove the sugary foods that the bacteria use to grow.



The sharp, chisel-shaped teeth at the front of your mouth are incisors. They can cut and bite tough food.

At about the age of eighteen, wisdom teeth may come through at the back of your mouth—but they don't make you wise!

Premolars have two edges, or cusps. They tear and grind up your food.

